

Student Credentials Annotated Bibliography



Prepared by Kelly Haines, Senior Research Associate/Program Manager at Think College, Institute for Community Inclusion

As part of the credentials innovation exchange, Think College keeps abreast of new information and resources that can support stakeholders considering the characteristics of “meaningful credentials” for students with intellectual disabilities (ID) in postsecondary education. The resources listed here include reports, briefs, peer-reviewed journal articles, and federal guidance on the topic of credentials. As knowledge about credentials available to students with ID continues to develop, it is important to consider the context of the credential landscape nationally. This annotated bibliography offers a summary of information and insights that can be drawn from existing credential resources.

Think College publications and archived webinars, as well as other recommended readings on the topic of credentials, are included in the appendix.

ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY

Austin, J., Mellow, G., Rosin, M., & Seltzer, M. (2012, November). Portable, stackable credentials: A new education model for industry-specific career pathways. McGraw-Hill Research Foundation. Retrieved from: <https://www.jff.org/resources/portable-stackable-credentials-new-education-model-industry-specific-career-pathways/>

This paper was produced by two university administrators, a private learning science company, and a nonprofit agency working in the areas of workforce and education. The authors offer a review of the postsecondary education system, citing several statistics related to access and attainment of credentials and follow with a short discussion of connections to supply and demand forces in the labor market. The goal of the paper is to make a case for a portable, stackable credentialing system that is built upon a career pathways framework in the U.S. Several examples from countries outside the U.S. are provided which tie in related topics such as apprenticeships, vocational training, and school-to-work initiatives. The authors also offer a summary of how the U.S. Departments of Education and Labor are supporting portable and stackable credentials and career pathways, including a short list of web-based resources that can help practitioners navigate competency models and credential identification. The paper closes with some short case studies of

promising practices in the U.S. One example touches on including disadvantaged students in a specific state, but not disability specifically.

Credential Engine. (2018, April). Counting U.S. secondary and postsecondary credentials: A Credential Engine report. Retrieved from: https://credentialengine.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/04/Counting_US_Secondary_and_Postsecondary_Credentials_April_2018.pdf

and

Cronen, S., McQuiggan, M., Isenberg, E., & Grady, S. (2018, February). Adult training and education: Results from the National Household Education Surveys Program of 2016 (NCES 2017-103rev). First Look. U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences, National Center for Education Statistics. Washington, DC. Retrieved from: <https://nces.ed.gov/pubs2017/2017103rev.pdf>

Taken together, these two reports provide a snapshot of the number of credentials available in the U.S. and the number of individuals reported to have specific credentials.

Credential Engine is a non-profit organization that produced this report with support from the Lumina Foundation, and research services from the Center for Regional Economic Competitiveness and George Washington University Institute for Public Policy. The report seeks to provide a definitive number of credentials available in the U.S., as a first step in a process toward developing recommendations for how individuals (students, hiring managers, educators, etc.) can interpret information about the value of credentials. The report offers definitions of 23 different types of credentials, and uses a number of data sources to provide numerical counts of credential availability in the U.S. including the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), U.S. Department of Labor Employment and Training Administration ApprenticeshipUSA, License Finder, and Certification Finder, and online programs like edX and Udacity. The authors estimate that there are over 300,000 credentials currently available in the U.S. This information serves a baseline for overall estimates of the general credential landscape.

Prepared by the American Institutes for Research, the second report summarizes results from the Adult Training and Education Survey (ATES) which was administered as part of the 2016 National Household Education Surveys Program. The survey was intended to capture the prevalence of nondegree credentials (e.g. occupational certification or licenses and postsecondary educational certificates) and information about work experience programs. Descriptive statistics including frequencies and percentages are reported for the survey sample of noninstitutionalized adults ages 16-65 who are not enrolled in high school. Overall, 27% of adults reported having a nondegree credential, and 21% of adults reported completing a work experience program.

What is missing from both the Credential Engine report and the ATES survey report is information about the availability of credentials accessed and obtained by students with disabilities, or specifically students with ID.

Deterding, N., & Pedulla, D. (2016). Educational authority in the “open door” marketplace: Labor market consequences of for-profit, nonprofit, and fictional educational credentials. *Sociology of Education*, 89(3), 155-170.

This article was published in the peer-reviewed academic journal *Sociology of Education* by two university-based authors. The authors used a field-experiment to explore employers’ response to job applicants listing an associate degree from either a fictional college, local for-profit college, or a nonprofit institution. While the focus of this research was to explore how employers respond to degrees from for-profit institutions, the authors generalize the context to consider how employers evaluate credentials from what may be considered an “emerging institution” within the larger context of the expanding credential landscape. The study results indicate that holding a postsecondary credential provides a slight benefit to applicants for some employers; but that the institution is not really considered as a factor in employer decision making. The authors consider these results in a complex discussion that touches on several different sociological theories of hiring. Disability and postsecondary education researchers and policymakers may find interest in the sociological theories presented here, and programs serving students with ID may identify as “emerging institutions” but it is difficult to glean

concrete recommendations or best practices from this paper. Note: see Deming, D. J., Yuchtman, N., Abulafi, A., Goldin, C., & Katz, L. F. (2016). The value of postsecondary credentials in the labor market: An experimental study. *American Economic Review*, 106(3), 778-806. for a similar study yielding comparable results.

Duke-Benfield, A.E., Wilson, B., Kaleba, K., & Leventoff, J. (2019, September). Defining quality non-degree credentials for states. National Skills Coalition. Washington, DC.

The National Skills Coalition (NSC) partnered with states to develop a consensus definition of non-degree credentials and establish criteria for assessing the quality of these credentials. The purpose of this report is to assist states, policymakers, students, and employers to better understand which programs are of high quality and inform policies that promote attainment of these credentials. The NSC places an emphasis on how states can address racial and other equity gaps – occasionally mentioning disability specifically – when developing pathways to postsecondary education and good jobs. This paper can offer specific guideposts to postsecondary programs serving students with ID that are working to develop credentials that have value in today’s labor market. As a broad-based coalition, the NSC serves a wide range of U.S. workers and industries.

Florida Consortium on Inclusive Higher Education. (2019). Florida IPSE credential guidance brief series. Retrieved from www.fcihe.com/resources.

The Florida Consortium on Inclusive Higher Education (FCIHE) developed a set of six briefs to provide guidance to Florida stakeholders regarding credential development for inclusive postsecondary education programs for students with ID. The briefs cover: 1) Background on Inclusive Postsecondary Education; 2) Programs of Study; 3) Exploring Existing Credentials; 4) Partnerships Toward Credential Development; 5) FCIHE Credential Action Planning Tool; and 6) Credentialing Resources (an annotated bibliography). This brief series is specific to Florida, and provides several detailed descriptions of existing credentials in the Florida postsecondary education system; however, much of the information presented could be applicable across states and programs. The series’ intended audience broadly includes faculty/educators, families, and community agency and school district personnel.

Gallagher, S. (2017, February). Aligning higher education credentials. National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE) Center for Career Development and Talent Acquisition. Retrieved from: www.nacweb.org/job-market/trends-and-predictions/aligning-higher-education-credentials/

This article was published online by the National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE) journal housed at the NACE Center, a not-for-profit organization. The university-based author conducted research over a three-year period that included conversations with hundreds of employers and reviews of academic literature and data, and concluded that the need for college-employer collaboration is the most critical outcome of the study. The article includes a short historical overview of the recent expansion of the credential landscape to include micro and nano credentials and the associated growth of credential-related companies, and includes the employer point of view in interpreting the value – and skills/competencies – potentially associated with new and emerging types of credentials. With the growing emphasis on employment outcomes for students seeking credentials, the author puts employers at the center of the higher education credential issue, calling them the emerging “arbiters of higher education quality.” This article reads as an editorial, calling for colleges to engage with the employer community in more significant ways than traditional structures such as advisory boards, but it does not offer specific recommendations or strategies for how to facilitate employer engagement.

Lumina Foundation. (2015). Connecting credentials: A beta credentials framework. Retrieved from: <https://connectingcredentials.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/05/ConnectingCredentials-4-29-30.pdf>

The Lumina Foundation is a private foundation with a body of work focused on increasing the attainment of degrees and other credentials for Americans. It sponsored this paper developed by the Corporation for a Skilled Workforce and the Center for Law and Social Policy. The framework presented in the paper is based on competencies for specific credentials. Unlike some other resources, this paper notes the connection between credentials and accreditation, indicating that less than 10% of the more than 4,000 personnel-certification bodies are accredited or reviewed by an outside party. The framework itself is general to any subject matter while also being highly specific with regard to the knowledge and skills

described in each of eight levels. Additional skills are described including specialized skills, personal skills, and social skills. The authors make (insert a) special point to describe their choice of the word “skills” (which can be learned) over the typical use of “abilities” in the traditional Knowledge/Skills/Abilities model. This could be of value to readers who approach it from a disability perspective. The authors encourage users to try to use the framework in their own institutions and provide feedback that may improve future iterations. The values presented are consistent with other recent resources, and include equity (of access), transparency, comparability, and portability.

The Council of Chief State School Officers (CCSSO), Education Strategy Group (ESG), & Advance CTE. (2018). Credential currency: How states can identify and promote credentials of value. Retrieved from <http://edstrategy.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/ESG-Credential-Currency-Full-Report.pdf>

The 2018 Credential Currency report states that post-high school credentials—anything from certificate and licenses to college degrees—have become a requirement for career success in today's labor market. The report provides recommendations for how states can promote credentials of value while also focusing on ensuring students have equitable access.

Focusing specifically on the part of the credential spectrum between high school diplomas and postsecondary degrees, the authors offer their definition of “credentials of value” but do not endorse any specific state's definition of “industry recognized credentials” which can vary.

Although the authors mention equity of access, they do not identify specific disadvantaged groups (including disability) or offer specific recommendations for targeting underserved populations but rather encourage states to systematically collect, analyze, and report on credential access data as a critical step. The report is easy to read and includes visual graphics and often uses short, bulleted lists to convey information. It serves as a good foundational read for the NSC 2019 report.

U.S. Department of Education, Office of Vocational and Adult Education. (2012). Integrating industry-driven competencies in education and training through employer engagement. Washington, D.C. Retrieved from: https://www.rti.org/sites/default/files/resources/brief_4_employer_engagement_final.pdf

This brief report was developed for the Community College Virtual Symposium as part of a project of the U.S. Department of Education, Office of Vocational and Adult Education. The purpose of the brief is to spark discussion about employer engagement in curriculum development, and the authors offer four case studies of partnership efforts to support curriculum development that are employer or industry specific (e.g. McDonalds; Automotive Manufacturing). The focus is limited to community colleges, and the brief does not mention disability, but lessons may be applicable to other types of IHEs and training programs that share similar goals of effectively preparing workers for jobs and meeting local labor market demands.

U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration, Advisory System. (2016). Credential Resource Guide – TEGL 15-10, Attachment 2. Retrieved from: <https://wdr.doleta.gov/directives/attach/TEGL15-10.pdf>

This advisory issued by the Employment and Training Administration consists of a training and employment guidance letter (TEGL) issued to state and local workforce boards, agencies, administrations, and liaisons, as well as state labor commissions, and apprenticeship agencies and grant recipients in the areas of trade adjustment and community-based job training. In a footnote on the first page, the letter explicitly defines what a “credential” means for training and employment, and also offers definitions of the term “industry-recognized” and provides examples for several industries. The letter goes on to provide the federal agency’s view of the value of credentials, statistics related to credential attainment, and performance goals for the future. Strategies for improving the value of credentials to program participants are offered, and a list of key questions to consider are especially useful for programs developing credentials, such as: “Is the credential recognized by employers and used in hiring, promotion, and compensation decisions?” and “Is the credential embedded in a larger career pathway model...?” This federal guidance can be used as a reflection exercise for programs considering developing or refining credentials offered to students with ID.

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

THINK COLLEGE PUBLICATIONS

- Grigal, M., Hart, D., Smith, F., Papay, C., & Domin, D. (2018). Year Three Annual Report of the TPSID Model Demonstration Projects (2017–2018). Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.
- Lee, S., Rozell, D., & Will, M. (2018). Addressing the Policy Tangle: Students with Intellectual Disability and the Path to Postsecondary Education, Employment and Community Living. Washington, DC: Inclusive Higher Education Committee.
- Shanley, J., Weir, C., Grigal, M. (2014). Credential Development in Inclusive Higher Education Programs. Serving Students with Intellectual Disabilities. Think College Insight Brief, Issue No. 25. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion
- Think College. (n.d.). Requirements of Comprehensive Transition Programs. Retrieved from <https://thinkcollege.net/think-college-learn/comprehensive-transition-programs/requirements-comprehensive-transition-programs>

OTHER READING

- Bills, D. B., Di Stasio, V., & Gërxhani, K. (2017). The demand side of hiring: Employers in the labor market. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 43, 291-310.
- Hora, M. T. (2018). Hiring as cultural gatekeeping into occupational communities: Implications for college students, faculty, and career advisors. W CER Working Paper No. 2018-1. University of Wisconsin–Madison, Wisconsin Center for Education Research. Retrieved from: www.wcer.wisc.edu/publications/working-papers
- Pappano, L. (2017, April 27). When a college degree isn’t enough. *The Atlantic*. Retrieved from www.theatlantic.com/
- Visher, M., & Stern, D. (2015). New pathways to careers and college: Examples, evidence, and prospects. MDRC. Retrieved from: www.mdrc.org/publication/new-pathways-careers-and-college
- Wilson, B. (2016). Stackable Credential Policy: 50-State Scan. National Skills Coalition. Retrieved from: www.nationalskillscoalition.org/resources/publications/file/Stackable-Credential-Scan-2.pdf
- Workforce Strategy Center. (2009). Employers, low-income young adults, and postsecondary credentials: A practical typology for business, education, and community leaders. Retrieved from: www.careerladdersproject.org/docs/WSC_employer_involvement_2009.10.20.pdf



This is a publication of Think College, a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston, funded by a grant from the Office of Postsecondary Education (Grant No. P407B100002). The opinions contained in this document are those of the grantee and do not necessarily reflect those of the funder.

www.ThinkCollege.net